

38 Discourse on the Establishment of Awareness — Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · YouTube Talks · 22:37

Sorry about that. I trust you had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, although I hope it has been happy.

*Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā sambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato
Sammā sambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā sambuddhassa.*

So we have a few people joining us this evening who are doing the Gaia House Course. Those of you who are doing the Gaia Course, I'm presuming that you've listened to those three talks that I mentioned which you find on the website under Gaia House and it has a title underneath it "Personal Retreat". So I'm hoping that you've looked at the first one, which is the technique, and what we've been doing in the evening is looking at the various discourses that the Buddha gave and trying to find some meaning in them.

So in tune with this particular course, I'm going to look at the *Satipaṭṭhāna* discourse, the discourse on how to establish right awareness. Now, there are very good books now on this, which again, I've put on the website. Bhikkhu Anālayo has written an academic study of it. But one of the classics is *The Heart of Buddhist Meditation* by Nyanaponika Thera, who was a very famous German monk in his time. He was the one that began the Buddhist Publication Society up in Kandy, which publishes all the books. And he was one of Bhikkhu Bodhi's teachers.

There's also *Mindfulness* by Joseph Goldstein, which was modeled on Anālayo's book, by the way. Well, at least he took that as the base. And there's always Sayadaw U Pandita's *In This Very Life*. So there's lots of literature out there. And all I'm going to do is just go through it making occasional comments just so that you are familiar with the actual discourse, and then hopefully you'll read those books. Not necessary to become fully liberated, by the way. Don't need any of this. But if you're going to have a pastime, this is a very skillful way to use your time.

So the structure of the sutta is, first of all, he lays out what he's going to talk about. And then we have the body. So he talks about the body, the breath, the postures, awareness in ordinary daily life, the repulsiveness of the body. He's very much into the body. The elements, of course, the four elements. And finally, the charnel grounds, mindfulness of death. Then he talks about feelings, both physical feelings and mental feelings caused in the body by emotions. The contemplating of the mind, of mental states, he goes into that. And then finally, contemplation of things. Actually, it's contemplation of the Dhamma, looking at it from various angles, the hindrances, the seven factors of enlightenment, the sense spheres.

Now, I'm using here a translation by Bhikkhu Ānandajoti, who's an English monk marooned in Thailand. He doesn't want to come back to England, to Britain, because it's too cold, he says. And he's quite a good scholar, quite a good translator. If you go into his websites, he's got one with lots of translations and comments, and he's got another one with all sorts of documentaries and films, and another one which is an endless row of photographs. He's a keen photographer.

So let's begin. "Thus have I heard" — remember all these discourses were remembered by, so the tradition tells us, by Ānanda, who was his companion for about twenty years at the end of his life. "At one time, the Blessed One was dwelling amongst the Kurus near the market town of the Kurus named Kammāsadhamma." So they think this was near Delhi, by the way. So he really moved around that North Gangetic plain.

Now, the important thing, one of the things that the commentary says was that he was very taken by the Kurus because he'd been there before. And when he returned, he found them being very mindful. There was no well talk, you know, the gossip around the well. And so he was very struck by that. And it was at that time that he gave this discourse. So we can say that when he gave this discourse — this is just my own understanding — that he really was thinking about lay people.

But not entirely so, because there's a group of monks whom he meets coming out of meditation in the jungles of the forest back to the monastery, and he points out that some of them were using *samatha* and *vipassanā* and some of them were using only *vipassanā* as their main vehicle. And this discourse is really about *vipassanā* as the path without the other concentration exercises. And of course, the Mahāsi system is basically a *vipassanā*-only path. But we'll come to that.

So he's now asked them to listen to him. Now, the opening line is, "This is, monks, a one-way path" — this word, *ekāyano*. Sometimes it's translated in a fundamentalist way: "This is the only path." And then it's "the single path," "the direct path." And he's translated as "a one-way path," meaning that you can only go along it. You can't come back on it. But the commentaries also point out that it's in opposition to the *dvāya no*, the two-way path, which is of concentration and *vipassanā*. One of the great teachers of that was Ajahn Mahā Bua, whom some of you might know from Thailand. He didn't die so long ago and was an Arahant — declared himself to be an Arahant in so many words.

So he starts off by telling us that this is the one-way path, pure *vipassanā*, pure *vipassanā*. And he tells us that this is "for the purification of beings" — that comes first, the purification of beings — "for the overcoming of grief and lamentation," the sorrow of life, "for the extinction of pain and sorrow." Now, this pain is both the physical pain and eventually sorrow, but pain, of course, in the body is natural to the body. So really, this is the pain in the body caused by the mind. "And this is for attaining the right way, the direct realization of *Nibbāna*."

Now, *Nibbāna* is another word which has various meanings. It can mean that there is no more desire, but it also has a meaning of being unshackled, released. And referring to this awareness which is shackled by

its misunderstandings with the psychophysical organism — put in the Buddhist teaching, these are the five *khandhas*, the five aggregates — and it's by pulling itself out of that through this practice that it unshackles itself.

So there are four ways in which we do it. He dwells contemplating the body in the body. Now, this is another thing. Sometimes it's translated as "the body as the body," but actually, the grammar of it is — for those of you who know the locative — it's like being in a room. So it's actually contemplating the body in the body. And to me, that's the Buddha stressing the fact that you've got to get into things. You've got to actually absorb or absorb into your experience within yourself. One of my teachers, Sayadaw U Pandita, used to talk about plunging, plunging into the object.

And he does it "with ardour." Ardour — this word *ātāpī* is a very strong word. It reminds, it's the sort of word you'd use with self-mortification exercises. And the commentary says that you've got to be as ardent until you've burnt out all the defilements. So it's a real commitment. "Fully aware and mindful" — now again, this *sampajāno satimaṃ*, they're both adjectives: mindfully and fully aware. This *pajāno*, it really is the same word as *pajānāti*, as *paññā*, which means wisdom when you've got it and the process of insight. And so this is, I think, better translated as with intuitive awareness, intuitive intelligence and awareness.

So when you combine them, it's intuitive awareness. The awareness is what's receiving the information. The intuition is what understands it, grasps it. So we have it in our language when we say, "Go and have a look and see what it is." So first of all, you look and then you see and you understand.

"After removing *abhijjhā*" — sometimes this is translated as "desire for worldly things," "for worldly pleasures and sorrow regarding the world." I mean, you'll all have experienced those if you've been on retreat. That there's a, towards the end of a retreat, there's a longing to get back to your family, to your friends, to your hobbies and things like that. So it's that pull that the outer world always has upon us. And sorrow, we might feel unhappy about the world. And these things we have to, as it were, put aside when we're meditating. You don't forget them. You're just parking them. Remember, there's a distinction between suppressing something which we do out of aversion or fear and just taking our attention away from it for a while, just putting them to the side, picking them up when the retreat is over or whatever.

And he contemplates feelings in feelings, fully aware, mindful, and removing this desire for the world and sorrow. And he contemplates the mind — so these are mental states in mental states — and fully aware, etc. And then finally contemplating things. Now, *Ānandajoti* is translated as "things," but actually it's the actual Dhamma. So I think we've been through that, those things like the hindrances, seven factors of enlightenment, the Four Noble Truths.

So he's made a very broad statement there that it's about contemplating in this *vipassanā* way, in this insightful way, the body, the feelings in the body, the mental states that we suffer from, and looking at what is actually arising from a Dhamma point of view. So that's the summary. That's the summary of it.

And then he goes into contemplating of the body. And there are different sections of this. So I'll just — looks as though time is passing. By the way, those of you who are on retreat, this may take me a few days to get through the discourse. You are, of course, welcome to join in the evening. And I usually, well, I do post up the talk, the evening talk, the next day. Just takes a little while for me to do it.

So he says that, well, he's talking now specifically about monks going into the wilderness, to the root of a tree, to an empty space and all that. But basically, folding his legs crosswise and setting his body straight. So we needn't take that too literally. You can sit, you can do with your legs what you want. You can take them off if you want. It's basically keeping the body straight, keeping the body energized, lifting it, and establishing mindfulness in front of him. In other words, bringing mindfulness to bear.

So he breathes in mindful and he breathes out mindful. And then it says that "while breathing in long, he knows 'I am breathing in long.' And when breathing out, he knows 'I am breathing out long'" and then breathing short and then breathing out short. So this is your beginning. This is contacting the breath as you feel it, whenever you sit down, whenever you start your practice, unless there's something immediate that draws your attention. I mean, if you sit down, if you just had a big upset, for instance, and you sit down and you have to deal with this upsetting feeling — somebody's let you down or made you angry or whatever — then of course you would go immediately to that. You wouldn't go to the breath. But normally speaking, you would begin with the breath. And of course, what he's saying is just get in contact with it. Know that it's long, know that it's short.

And then, "experiencing the whole body, I will breathe in, experiencing the whole body, I'll breathe out." So, having contacted the breath and got the feeling of it, one then begins to stay with the full length of the body. The body of the breath is the body here. It isn't the body. It's the body of the breath, the beginning, the middle section and the end. Now, when you do that, you're not looking for a middle point of your breath. You're beginning at the — the beginning is the moment it begins. The whole business of coming to the end of the in-breath is the middle, and the end is the end. So it's beginning, middle and end, and it's the beginning, middle, and end of the out-breath.

And he says, "calming the body process, I will breathe in and breathe out." Now, it's not as though you do that purposefully. As soon as you put your attention on the breath, you will feel this calmness come and you keep doing it until the calmness becomes established. It's not something that you force upon yourself.

So the example, he says, is of a clever turner or turner's apprentice. This is on a machine that carves wood, a bowl or something. "I am making a long turn." And while making a short turn, he knows "I'm making a short turn." "And so monks, a monk while breathing knows 'I'm breathing long.' And while breathing out, he knows 'I'm breathing out long.' He knows 'I'm breathing in short and breathing out short.' Experiencing the whole body, he trains himself this way. Experiencing the whole body, I breathe out." That's the whole body of the breath. "Calming the bodily process, I breathe in. Calming the bodily process, I breathe out."

So there you've got three points there where you first of all contact the breath, then you settle into the

breath, and very slowly the breath begins to create — just the fact of making a neutral, quiet sensation the object of your meditation has the effect of silencing the mind, calming the heart and stilling the body.

Now, you have to be careful not to take this too literally. In no tradition that I've worked with does it say that you're supposed to be saying "I am breathing out." One of the problems of Pali is it doesn't have a passive voice. So you can't say "the breath is being breathed." In English, we can say "they drove the car." And then we can turn it around and say "the car was driven by them." Well, you can't say that in Pali. So you've only got an active sense. And the commentaries point out that a dog or a jackal knows where they're going and they know where they're sitting down. But obviously they don't say it. So it's just really a recognition.

Now, the word that is used is *pajānāti*. So it's not a case of just knowing that the breath is rising or falling. It's knowing in a particular way. So remember this word *pajānāti*, the noun is *paññā*, wisdom, insight. So it's looking at it from the three characteristics of existence. The relationship we have with things, wanting, not wanting, impermanence — mainly it's impermanence with the breath. And of course, the body is breathing. It's not me. When you're watching the body, the body is just breathing. So there's your *anattā*, it's not me.

So that brings us to the breath, which — time is moving on. What I'll do is just the next bit. And just the last little frame where he says he dwells contemplating the body in the body with regard to himself, so he does it with himself. But it also, with regard to others, and the commentaries are quite clear, that you're sometimes aware of other people breathing. And in meditation halls, I'm sure you've experienced people with heavy breaths, noisy breaths coming through the nose. And instead of getting really uptight about that and wanting to strangle them, you can use it as a meditational object. The beginning, the rising and the falling — it's all impermanent. And of course, both ways in regards to oneself and in regards to the other.

So that brings us to the end of the section on breathing. And I think we might leave it there. It might take me some time just to make my way through this discourse, but I think it's worth doing it.

So I can, as usual, I do hope my words have been of some assistance and they have not caused any confusion. If they have, of course, you can always email me. And that by your devotion to practice, you will be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

So we can begin our sitting meditation.

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